



WMD

Ryu's weapons stash has changed a bit compared to *Ninja Gaiden 2*. There are two ranged weapons available including a new one called Howling Cannon. All other ranged weapons from the Xbox360 version have been left out. Simple shurikens are permanently mapped to a button on the gamepad and always available to be thrown in conjunction with any of the other two ranged weapons.

On the other hand, all melee weapons have been retained and additionally Dablahro makes a comeback in its new avatar of Enma's Fang. Upgrading weapons does not cost anything in this version, but it is tightly controlled. Not all Muramasa shops will have the option of upgrading weapons and the upgrade level is locked with progress of the game.

From the Dojo of Colossal Bosoms

Rachel, the demon huntress from the first Sigma game makes a comeback as a playable character. Joining forces with her are two other familiar maidens—the ninja Ayane and the shrine maiden Momiji. They each come with their exclusive arsenal— a melee weapon, a ranged weapon and a Nimpo power— along with the infamous Sixaxis Support.

There is also one level dedicated to each of the three characters, woven into the main storyline. Once you have finished these chapters, that particular character becomes available for the multiplayer co-op mode. These female characters may appear to be frail and even vain; however they are well designed and can easily hold their own against the enemy horde.

Master Ninja

Visually the game appears to be an improvement over the X360 version. It justifies the 3GB+ installation with visibly improved frame rate. The game can also

output graphics at full HD resolution (1080p), something that is not very common on the PlayStation 3. Also, textures appear to be of higher quality and the colors are more vivid. On the flipside however, there are stray issues with collision detection while in combat.

Feat of Hundred Slashes

If you have not played *Ninja Gaiden* before, mainly due to the challenging combat, we would suggest giving this one a go. Even though this game is not as simple as most of the other beat-'em ups, Sigma 2 has been rebalanced to favor the player.

Relatively speaking, the game also packs a lot of content— for a first timer, the single player campaign can take about ten hours to complete. After you've done that there are "Chapter Challenge" and "Team Mission" modes to keep you busy for another few hours. At the end of all this, if you are feeling cocky you could attempt to beat the game at Mentor and subsequently Master difficulty—not a simple task by any means. If you like collecting game trophies, there are trophies for mastering all four playable characters, their weapons, Nimpo and even some special moves.

Ninja Gaiden is one of the best action game series ever made and if you are apprehensive about investing in this one, you should at least try the demo of Sigma 2 which is available on the PSN store—you may be pleasantly surprised.

THE SKOAR

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